



PRELUDE
LEARNING & CONSULTANCY

FREE RESOURCE · ASSESSMENT TOOLKIT

Workforce Capability Assessment

A structured way to map your workforce's capability against what the organisation actually needs, find the gaps that matter most and decide what to do about them.

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BEFORE YOU START

About this toolkit

Most organisations know roughly where their people are strong and weak. Fewer can show which gaps put delivery at risk, which can wait, and which will not be fixed by training at all.

This toolkit takes you through eight steps, from the outcomes the workforce must deliver to a prioritised, owned improvement plan. It works for a single team or a whole organisation, and for commercial businesses, SMEs, public bodies, charities and regulated industries alike. Scale the effort to the decision: a small business might complete it in a morning for five roles; a large organisation might use it to structure a programme of work.

The eight steps

#	Step	Output	Template
1	Define workforce requirements	The outcomes and demand the workforce must meet	—
2	Identify roles and responsibilities	A list of roles in scope, with their criticality	—
3	Define capabilities and standards	The capabilities that matter and the level each role needs	—
4	Map knowledge and skills to roles	Required capability by role	A · Role capability matrix
5	Assess the current state and gather evidence	Current capability, with its evidence	B · Current vs required D · Evidence register
6	Analyse gaps and criticality	Gaps ranked by size and consequence	C · Gap and criticality matrix
7	Set priorities, including non-training interventions	The right response to each priority gap; workforce risks	—
8	Plan, act and evaluate	An owned, measurable improvement plan	E · Prioritised improvement plan

Capability and competency

In this toolkit, a **capability** is something the organisation needs people to be able to do (for example “manage a complaint to resolution” or “plan and run a safe site inspection”). **Competency** describes an individual's demonstrated ability against that capability at the level the role requires. Organisational capability also depends on processes, systems, structure and leadership, which is why step 7 looks beyond training.

USE WHAT YOU ALREADY HAVE

If your organisation or sector already uses a competency or skills framework, use its definitions and levels rather than creating new ones. This toolkit provides a structure for the assessment, not a replacement framework. Results are indicative and depend on the quality of the evidence gathered; they are not a validated psychometric or audit measure.

STEPS 1 – 2

Workforce requirements, roles and responsibilities

Step 1 · Define what the workforce must deliver

Start with outcomes, not with people. Capture what the organisation must achieve over the period you are planning for and what will drive demand for capability.

Outcomes the workforce must deliver
(services, products, standards, targets)

Changes on the horizon (growth, new services, technology, regulation, restructuring)

Standards that are non-negotiable
(safety, legal, regulatory, contractual, quality)

Planning horizon and scope of this assessment

Step 2 · Identify the roles in scope

List the roles (not the individuals) that deliver those outcomes. Rate each role's **criticality**: the consequence for the organisation if the role could not be performed to standard.

Criticality	Meaning
High	Failure would stop a core service, create a safety, legal or regulatory breach, or cause serious financial or reputational harm.
Medium	Failure would significantly reduce quality, efficiency or customer experience, but could be contained for a period.
Low	Failure would cause inconvenience but could be covered or deferred.

Role	Main responsibilities	Number of people	Criticality (H / M / L)	Single points of failure?

STEPS 3 – 4

Capabilities, standards and mapping

Step 3 · Define the capabilities that matter

Identify the capabilities needed to deliver the outcomes from step 1. Keep the list short enough to assess properly: for most teams, eight to fifteen capabilities is enough. Include technical capabilities, and the behavioural and management capabilities that make them work.

- Describe each capability in observable terms: what someone does, not what they know about.
- Separate capabilities that everyone needs from those specific to certain roles.
- Note any capability that requires a qualification, licence or authorisation.

Set the required standard

Use a proficiency scale to describe the level each role needs. If you have no existing scale, the example below is a practical starting point:

Level	Label	Description
0	Not required	The role does not need this capability.
1	Awareness	Understands what it is and when it applies; knows who to go to.
2	Working	Performs routine tasks to standard with occasional guidance.
3	Practitioner	Performs independently to standard, including non-routine situations.
4	Expert	Sets standards, solves complex problems, develops and assures others.

Example scale only. Adapt the labels and descriptions to your context or replace with your existing framework.

Step 4 · Map capabilities to roles

Use **Template A** to record the required level of each capability for each role. This is the “required” picture against which the current state will be compared. Validate it with the people who manage and perform the roles: requirements written only by HR or a central team are often over- or under-specified.

CHECK THE REQUIREMENT BEFORE ASSESSING PEOPLE

If managers disagree about the level a role needs, resolve that first. A gap measured against a disputed standard will not be acted on.

Template A · Role capability matrix (required levels)

Enter capabilities across the top and roles down the side. In each cell, record the required level (0–4). Shade or mark cells where the capability is critical to the role.

Role ↓ Capability →												

Levels: 0 Not required · 1 Awareness · 2 Working · 3 Practitioner · 4 Expert

STEP 5

Assess the current state and gather evidence

The quality of the assessment depends almost entirely on the quality of the evidence.

Assessment methods

Method	Strengths	Limitations
Self-assessment	Quick, scalable, engages staff	People over- or under-rate themselves; best combined with another method
Manager assessment	Informed by day-to-day observation	Varies by manager; affected by relationships and recent events
Observation or work sampling	Shows real performance in context	Time-consuming; behaviour may change when observed
Practical assessment or test	Consistent and defensible	Costly to design; may not reflect real conditions
Records and data	Objective: qualifications, quality data, errors, complaints	Shows outcomes, not always the cause

Good practice

- Use at least two methods for high-criticality capabilities.
- **Calibrate:** have managers compare and discuss their ratings before finalising, so the same level means the same thing across teams.
- Assess against the role standard, not against colleagues.
- Record the evidence for each rating in the evidence register (**Template D**).
- Explain to staff why the assessment is happening and how results will be used. Assessments perceived as performance management produce defensive answers.

DATA PROTECTION

Individual capability ratings are personal data. Agree the purpose, who can see individual results, how long they are kept and how they will be used before you start, in line with your organisation's data protection arrangements. Reporting at team or role level is often sufficient for planning.

Template B · Current versus required capability

For each role (or team), record the required level from Template A, the assessed current level and the gap. Use one sheet per role or team.

[illegible]

STEP 6

Analyse gaps and criticality

Not every gap matters equally. Rank each gap by two factors: how large it is and how critical the capability is to the role and the organisation.

Template C · Gap and criticality matrix

Place each gap (by its reference number) in the cell that matches its size and criticality. Gap size: Small = one level or a few people; Large = two or more levels, or most people below standard.

Criticality ↓ / Gap →	Small gap	Moderate gap	Large gap
High	Priority 2	Priority 1	Priority 1
Medium	Priority 3	Priority 2	Priority 2
Low	Monitor	Priority 3	Priority 3

Ref	Gap (role and capability)	Gap size (S / M / L)	Criticality (H / M / L)	Priority	Likely cause(s)
G1					
G2					
G3					
G4					
G5					
G6					
G7					
G8					

Ask “why?” before “what training?”

For each Priority 1 and 2 gap, test the cause. Is the knowledge or skill genuinely missing, or are capable people prevented from performing by process, tools, workload, unclear roles or management? The answer determines the response in step 7.

STEP 7

Development priorities and non-training interventions

Match the response to the cause. Training is one option among several.

If the main cause is...	Consider
Knowledge or skill genuinely missing	Training, coaching, mentoring, supervised practice, job aids, communities of practice
Capability exists but is used inconsistently	Clear standards, checklists, management routines, feedback, quality checks
Process or procedure	Process redesign or simplification; updating procedures; removing conflicting instructions
Systems, tools or information	Configuration or system changes; better information at the point of need; equipment
Roles and structure	Clarifying responsibilities and decision rights; redesigning roles or hand-offs
Capacity and workload	Workload rebalancing, prioritisation, recruitment, temporary resource
Not enough of the capability in the organisation	Recruitment, redeployment, succession planning, partnering or buying in specialist support
Motivation, incentives or culture	Leadership attention, recognition, aligning targets and incentives with the desired behaviour

Workforce risks

Some capability risks are about supply rather than skill. Record them alongside the gaps.

Risk type	In our organisation	Rating (H / M / L)	Mitigation
Single points of failure (one person holds critical capability)			
Expected leavers or retirements in critical roles			
Hard-to-recruit skills			
Dependence on contractors or suppliers			
Qualifications or authorisations due to lapse			
Capability needed for planned change not yet available			

TEMPLATE D

Evidence register

Record the evidence behind each significant rating or finding, and how much weight it will bear.

#	Rating or finding	Evidence source and method	Date	Label (E / I / A)	Confidence (H / M / L)
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					
13					
14					

E = evidence (directly observed or recorded) · I = inference (reasonable conclusion from evidence) · A = assumption (not yet tested)

STEP 8 · TEMPLATE E

Prioritised improvement plan and evaluation

Turn priority gaps and risks into owned actions with a measure of success. Start with Priority 1. Record dependencies: training on a process that is about to change is wasted effort.

Gap / risk ref.	Action	Type (training / non-training)	Depends on	Owner	Due	Measure of success

Evaluation

Decide now how you will know the plan has worked, and when you will check.

Baseline: current levels from Template B, and any operational measures

Leading indicators: early signs the actions are working (for example completions, observed practice, quality checks)

Outcome measures: the operational results the capability should improve

Reassessment date and who will carry it out

Repeat the assessment for priority roles at a planned interval, typically six to twelve months, using the same scale and methods so that results are comparable.

Working with Prelude

Prelude helps organisations of every size understand what capability they need, where the real gaps are and which interventions will close them. That can mean facilitating a workforce capability assessment, designing a capability framework, or diagnosing why previous development has not changed performance.

Facilitated assessment

Structured, calibrated assessment for priority roles or teams.

Capability frameworks

Practical frameworks people actually use for assessment and planning.

Discuss a challenge

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